

Project Time Tracker

User Guide

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What This Program Does

Project Time Tracker is a simple desktop program for accurately logging the time you spend on each project. You click a project's button to start a timer, click it again to stop, and each interaction is saved as a session log in memory until you save them to a personal Excel file/database.

In the session log viewer you are able to view each interaction, the order they occurred, the time they began and ended, the total time spent on each project for the day, and the total amount of time to charge to Overhead.

You save all of this information in your personal Excel file/database with the **Update Database** button, where you are able to view and search through this information.

Python Installation Guide:

1. Check if You Have Python Installed

If you already have a Python version equal to or greater than 3.9, skip to the Program Installation Guide.

1. **Win + R** -> Type **cmd** and hit **Enter** to open the command line -> Try these two different commands:
 - a. Type **Py -V** into the command line and hit **Enter**. If a result wasn't shown, try step b.
 - b. Type **python --version** into the command line and hit **Enter**.

2. Install Python

If you already have a Python version equal to or greater than 3.9, skip to the Program Installation Guide.

1. **Win + R** -> Type **cmd** and hit **Enter** to open the command line -> Type **winget install Python.Python.3.12** into the command line and hit **Enter** -> Wait for the installation window to complete. Python should now be downloaded.
2. To double check if Python is downloaded, go back to the command line -> Type **py -0** into the command line and hit **Enter** -> If you see **-V:3.12 Python 3.12 (64-bit)** outputted then Python 3.12 is installed.

Program Installation Guide:

Requirements:

- Python 3.9+
- openpyxl
- tzdata

1. Copy the Program Folder to Your Computer

You must copy the project folder from its original destination and paste it to a spot of your choosing on your computer. Choose a spot you can remember.

1. Copy the project folder found at **C:\Users\username\OneDrive – Wachter, Inc\WTS – Help Desk Sharepoint – Documents\Scripts and Tech Stuff\Adrian\Project Time Tracker\Project Time Tracker**
2. Paste the project folder **Project Time Tracker** (NOT the ZIP folder) in an easily rememberable and accessible place on your computer.

2. Install the Required Libraries

If at any point in this step the **setup.bat** file crashes, you don't have Python installed. Go back to the Python Installation Guide above.

1. Open the Project Time Tracker folder and double click the **setup.bat** file. Hit **Run**.
2. The command line will pop up. Wait until the libraries are done downloading and you see "Press any key to continue..."; this means you've successfully downloaded the libraries.

3. Open the Program

Test if the program works by opening it.

1. Open the Project Timer Tracker Folder and double click **project_time_tracker.py**

No problems? **Congrats! You're done!**

Setup and Usage Guide:

1. Set Up Your Profile (First Time Only)

Before tracking time, tell the program which shift you work and which time zone you're in. This makes sure your hours are dated and grouped correctly, especially if your shift crosses midnight.

1. Click **Options** in the top toolbar, then choose **Profile**.
2. Select your shift (1st, 2nd, or 3rd) from the dropdown.
3. Select your time zone from the dropdown.
4. Click **Save**.

You can change these settings anytime from the same menu. Entries you've already logged keep the shift and time zone that were active when you logged them — changing your profile later won't rewrite old entries in your database.

2. Create a Database

A "database" is just an Excel (.xlsx) file the program uses to store your logged time. **You need to create one before you can add project timers.**

Even though you can create multiple databases, **you only need one database for all your projects. I recommend that your database name includes every project you're apart of; Ex. *DellRouters_Rigado_Target***

1. Click **Create Database**.
2. Type a name for the database (for example, the project name or number). Commas separate multiple projects; spaces are removed automatically.
3. Choose where to save the file when the save window opens. A folder path is created for you automatically under **C:\Users\username\Documents\Project Tracker\db_<db name>**
4. Click **Save**. The file name now appears at the top of the window under "Current Database."

The Excel file has two tabs: **Daily Log** (every start/stop entry) and **Project Totals** (hours added up per project, per shift day). You won't need to edit either tab by hand.

3. Open an Existing Database

If you've already created a database in a previous session, use **Load Database** instead of creating a new one.

1. Click **Load Database** and select the .xlsx file.
2. Your project timers reload automatically with their original names.

If no timers appear after loading, the small name file that travels alongside the Excel file (same name, ending in .json) may be missing. You'll need to recreate the project timers with **Create Project Timer**.

If you have unsaved time entries when you create or load a database (or close the program), you'll be asked to confirm before they're discarded.

4. Add a Project Timer

You should create a timer for each project you want added to the database. **Because I recommend you add all your projects to the same database, I suggest creating a timer for each project you're on.**

1. Click **Create Project Timer**.
2. Enter the project name and project number, separated by a comma — for example: *Rigado, 123456*.
3. The project number must be at least 6 digits, numbers only.

A new square timer button appears in the main window. You can add as many project timers as you need.

5. Track Your Time

1. When you receive a call, click that project timer's **start** button to start its timer. The circle turns red, the button reads "Stop," and a live clock starts to count.
2. Click the same **stop** button to stop the timer. The call session is recorded automatically and the clock resets to 00:00:00.

Only one timer can run at a time. While a timer is running, every other button and timer in the program is locked until you stop it — this prevents accidentally starting a second timer or saving data mid-session.

6. Check Today's Data

Click **View Day's Data** to see a read-only summary of everything logged so far for your current shift day — this works whether or not you've clicked Update Database yet. **I recommend viewing this data at the end of your work day.** It shows:

1. Today's Log — every individual start/stop entry in order from when they were created.
2. Project Totals — hours per project, added up.
3. Overhead Total — 8 hours minus everything logged so far (goes negative, shown with a minus sign, if you've logged more than 8 hours).

Be warned: After you press the **Update Database** button all the current log data will be transferred to the Excel file/database, meaning it won't be viewable in View Day's Data any longer.

7. Save Your Time to the Database

Stopping a timer only records the entry in the log session memory — it does not touch the Excel file yet. To actually save your day's entries:

1. Click **Update Database**.
2. Your logged entries are appended to the Daily Log tab, and each project's running total for the shift day is updated in the Project Totals tab.

Do this as often as you like — clicking Update Database repeatedly on the same day appends to your Excel file/database and adds to your Project Totals rather than duplicating them. Once saved, the in-memory list clears so entries aren't saved twice.

8. Delete a Project Timer

No longer on a project? You can easily remove its timer from view. **Deleting the timer does NOT erase that project's time logs you've logged in View Day's Data or saved to the Excel file/database.**

1. Click **Delete Timer**. A small red "x" appears on every timer, and other buttons are disabled until you're done.
2. Click the "x" on the timer you want to remove, then confirm.
3. Click **Done Deleting** (same button, relabeled) when finished.

A running timer can't be deleted — stop it first.

9. Closing the Program

If you close the window while you have time entries that haven't been saved with Update Database, you'll be asked to confirm before they're lost. Click **No** to go back and save first.

Adding Program to Taskbar

Create a Shortcut and Add to Taskbar

Adding a script to the taskbar is tricky; we have to trick Windows to accept it.

1. Open your Project Time Tracker folder -> Right click **project_time_tracker.py** and select **Show more options** -> Click **Create shortcut** to create a shortcut in your folder
2. Right click the shortcut -> **Properties** -> Click **Target** -> type **explorer** in front of the path;
Ex. explorer "C:\Your\Path"
3. Drag the shortcut to your taskbar

The shortcut will have a folder icon. It's not pretty but it beats having to fish the program out File Explorer when you want to use it.

Quick Reference

Button	What it does
Create Database	Starts a brand-new Excel file to store your time.
Load Database	Reopens an existing Excel file and its project timers.
View Day's Data	Shows today's entries and totals without saving anything.

Update Database	Saves everything logged so far to the Excel file/database.
Options → Profile	Sets your shift and time zone.
Create Project Timer	Adds a new project button to track.
Delete Timer	Removes a project button from view.

Troubleshooting

“Missing Time Zone Data” error on startup

Open a command prompt and run: *pip install tzdata*, then restart the program.

A button is greyed out

Create Project Timer and Delete Timer stay disabled until a database is created or loaded. Most buttons also lock automatically while a timer is running or while Delete Timer mode is active.

No timers appeared after Load Database

The .json name file that belongs with that Excel file wasn't found in the same folder. Re-add your projects with Create Project Timer; the name file will be recreated automatically.